

PARENTING THROUGH GRIEF

Helping Kids Cope with Loss, Memory Book & Conversation Scripts

By Daniel Tesfamariam

HOW CHILDREN GRIEVE (By Age)

Under 3 years:

- Don't understand death but sense absence and parent's grief
- May regress (sleep, feeding, clinging)
- Need: routine, physical comfort, simple honest words

Ages 3-5:

- Think death is temporary/reversible (like sleep)
- Magical thinking ('Did I cause this?')
- May ask the same questions repeatedly
- Need: concrete explanations, reassurance, play-based processing

Ages 6-9:

- Understand death is permanent but may not grasp it happening to them
- May worry about other people dying
- Can seem fine then suddenly collapse in grief
- Need: factual info, permission to feel, continued normalcy

Ages 10-12:

- Understand death fully
- May hide emotions to 'protect' parents
- Risk of anger, acting out, withdrawal
- Need: honest conversations, peer support, counseling access

Teens:

- Grieve like adults but with fewer coping tools
- May turn to peers instead of parents
- Risk of substance use, reckless behavior
- Need: space AND availability, professional support offered

WHAT TO SAY (AND NOT SAY)

SAY:

- "[Person] died. Their body stopped working and cannot be fixed."
- "It is okay to cry. It is okay to feel angry. All feelings are allowed."
- "This is not your fault. Nothing you did caused this."
- "I am sad too. We can be sad together."
- "I don't know why this happened. I wish I did."
- "We will always remember [person]. They will always be part of our family."

DO NOT SAY:

- "They went to sleep" (causes fear of sleeping)
- "God needed another angel" (causes anger at God)
- "They went on a long trip" (causes confusion/abandonment)
- "You need to be strong for mommy" (suppresses grief)
- "At least they're not in pain" (minimizes the child's pain)
- "Don't cry, they wouldn't want you to be sad" (shames emotions)

CONVERSATION SCRIPTS FOR SPECIFIC LOSSES

Death of a grandparent:

"Grandma/Grandpa's body was very old and tired. It stopped working."

"They loved you so much. Let's talk about your favorite memories."

Death of a parent:

"Mommy/Daddy died. This means their body stopped working forever."

"You will always be safe. I am here. [Other person] is here."

"It is okay to feel anything. There is no wrong way to feel."

Death of a pet:

"[Pet name]'s body stopped working. They are not in pain."

"It is okay to miss them a lot. They were an important part of our family."

Death of a peer/classmate:

"Something very sad happened. [Name] died. This was not normal."

"You are safe. Would you like to talk about how you feel?"

MEMORY BOOK PAGES

Create a memory book together. Here are pages to fill:

Person I'm remembering: _____

My relationship to them: _____

My favorite memory with them: _____

Something funny they used to do: _____

A smell/sound/food that reminds me of them: _____

Something they taught me: _____

What I wish I could tell them: _____

How I feel today about them being gone: _____

Something that makes me smile when I think of them: _____

GRIEF SUPPORT STRATEGIES

Creating rituals:

- Light a candle on special days
- Visit a meaningful place together
- Make their favorite recipe on their birthday
- Write a letter to them (balloon release or burning)
- Plant a memorial tree or garden

Daily support:

- Keep routines as normal as possible
- Let them see you grieve (models healthy processing)
- Give permission for ALL feelings (including laughter and joy)
- Check in regularly but don't force conversation
- Expect grief waves at unpredictable times

When to get professional help:

- Prolonged sleep or appetite changes (2+ weeks)
- Talking about wanting to die or be with the person
- Inability to function at school/home
- Persistent nightmares or new fears
- Self-harm or substance use

Grief counselor: _____

Children's grief support group: _____

By Daniel Tesfamariam | Grief is love with nowhere to go. Let it flow.